leave for Bridge 5 when the booming of heavy mortars was heard. The Gorkhas were taken completely by surprise as the shells started to land around their positions as well. As the initial surprise wore off, the 1/9 GR 3-inch mortars opened up, but they were hopelessly out of range. The Chinese quickly got the bearings of the mortar positions and the battalion's four mortars were silenced.

Once the shelling stopped, the sound of small arms fire and grenades carried through to the Gorkhas from the valley below as the Chinese attacked the Rajput positions. Suddenly there was a burst fired from an LMG close to the Gorkha positions. As the inter-battalion telephone lines were all down by then, Ahluwalia sent his adjutant, Major Sher Pratap Singh Shrikent, to investigate. As the officer neared the Delta Company position, he could see the Chinese forming up to attack the forward position, while two other groups were also getting ready to assault both the flanking Alpha and Charlie Company positions.

By the time Shrikent scrambled back to the command post, the fighting had started in earnest. Those manning the command bunker told the adjutant that the CO had rushed off to Charlie Company as soon as the first shots were fired. The adjutant now sprinted to his own bunker where he found Tewari briefing Dalvi over the telephone on the developing situation. Back in the command bunker, Ahluwalia had returned with the news that a 500-strong force was attacking Charlie Company. The company commander, Major M. M. S. Gambhir, had already been killed, but Second Lieutenant B. D. Dogra, though wounded, was spiritedly holding out. Ahluwalia now told Subedar Major Jit Bahadur Chetri to take all available men from Battalion HQ and reinforce Dogra's position.

As the Rajputs below and the Gorkhas above were simultaneously fighting off the first Chinese waves, an Indian Air Force Dakota appeared at 6.25 a.m., preparing to drop off the first load of the morning at Tsangdhar. The Chinese infiltration parties that were moving between the Gorkhas and Tsangdhar to cut off the Hathung-la route, fired at the incoming aircraft, which banked steeply and quickly cleared out of the area.

The desperate fighting continued, but gradually the Chinese by sheer dint of numbers were gaining the upper hand. Dogra's platoon had been overrun, but despite his own injuries, he was still firing a LMG so that the remnants of his platoon could fall back. Both Ahluwalia and his 2IC, Major Anant Singh Charak, had gone to the Charlie Company location to watch